

Fellini and the Art of Psychodrama

“The meeting with oneself is, at first, the meeting with one's own shadow. The shadow is a tight passage, a narrow door, whose painful constriction no one is spared who goes down to the deep well. But one must learn to know oneself in order to know who one is. For what comes after the door is, surprisingly enough, a boundless expanse full of unprecedented uncertainty, with apparently no inside and no outside, no above and no below, no here and no there, no mine and no thine, no good and no bad.” - Carl Jung¹

Upon viewing selections of Federico Fellini's filmography, it is undeniable that he was an auteur of the highest order; however, by the 1960s the self-referential aspects of his work moved far beyond ambiguous biography or psycho-social commentary to embrace analysis of one's psyche. Part of the director's evolution to this inward-oriented phase involved actively linking the process of personal psychological analysis to the process of creating art, or more specifically, creating a film. In essence he exploits aspects of postmodernism with a seemingly modernist-expressionist flourish; however, he is not commenting on the nature of art in as much as he is commenting on the nature of the artist. In his case, the nature of the artist is most pronounced in a decades-spanning fascination with dreams, psychoanalysis, Jungian psychology, performance, memory, and illusion. There are hints in the early films, the “trilogy of character” and the “trilogy of salvation”, but Peter Bondanella notes “...the evolution of Fellini's film language in *La Dolce Vita* and afterward - most particularly in *8 ½* and *Giulietta degli spiriti* - would move beyond any overriding concern with the representation of social reality and concentrate upon the subjective, often irrational areas of human behavior connected with the psyche or the unconscious” (Bondanella, 2002, p. 26). *La Dolce Vita* hints at this self-referential process of psychoanalysis, but Fellini's meetings with Jungian therapist Ernst Bernhard prior to filming *8 ½* gave him the concrete language of analytical psychology to apply to his creative process (Ariano, 2020). He uses many Jungian concepts, most notably using film as his own personal psychodrama. Psychodrama is a group therapy technique that involves reenactments of memories, uncertainties, fantasy, dreams, or role-playing the future; it is unnecessary to stay within the confines of reality, although it can suggest reality, and ultimately aims to externalize inner processes for group examination and reflection (Beach, 2014; Scategni, 2014). Peter

¹ From. *Collected Works of C.G. Jung. Volume 9/1, Collected Works of C.G. Jung, Volume 9 (Part 1) ; Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious*, pp. 21.

Bondanella also makes an important point as to the gender aspect of Jungian psychodrama, noting the similarities between *8 ½* and *Juliet of the Spirits* as “two ...different sides of the same coin - an exploration of the Jungian anima and animus.” (Bondanella, 2002, p. 27). Given Fellini’s ongoing fascination with subjective truth, psyche, and sexual relations, it follows that the merger of film and psychodrama would be an ideal form of expressing Fellini’s understanding of the truth - not to define any objective truths in the world, but to offer a mirror upon which we may see our own subjective truths and complicated humanity reflected back upon us.

Much of Fellini’s style, motif usage, editing, compositions, framing, and lighting is consistent throughout his filmography: processions of people or images; dynamic camera movements that place us nearer to these worlds versus sitting back as an observer; characters that over-emote and seem to verge on blatant caricature or archetype; realistic scenes are juxtaposed with dream sequences, sometimes identifying themselves and sometimes chipping away at the barrier between illusion and reality; there are scenic, beautifully composed shots, that do not actively contribute to the narrative but evoke a visual “cinematic poetry”; characters are often ensconced in shadow, literally “in the dark” to some aspect of their own psyche; composition and framing alternate between intimate and distant, chaotic or serene, establishing relationship between audience and character; and the styles borrow from realism, expressionism, modernism, and surrealism, using a mixture of rhythms, symbols, visual metaphor, and subjective verisimilitude. *8 ½* and *Juliet of the Spirits* are no different, but turn inward to questions of psyche, as now Fellini begins establishing his role as both director and, through use of character, protagonist; these concepts, borrowed from Jungian psychodrama, allow Fellini to both stage the psychological drama as director and also express his own inner turmoil as protagonist - more importantly, as with psychodrama therapy, there is a larger group here, the viewer, to witness and participate in this staged “emotional memory” or inner conflict and, in the act of observing the process, become part of the process and gain personal insight (versus ascribing some objective meaning to it all) (Beach, 2014).

Jungian psychodrama itself is very much a spontaneous personal experience for all who participate, and thus the method or structure can vary contingent on the individuals involved in its production (Hill, 2014); looking exclusively at *8 ½* in that context, it appears Fellini borrowed the notion of mirroring, doubling, using a staged performance as a process of examining one’s ego, and emphasis on dreams. His self-insertion as protagonist of this psychoanalysis effectively utilizes the process while also commenting upon it. The film begins with Guido having a nightmare, trapped essentially in his own psyche and yearning to break free and fly away from the thoughts that plague him, a seeming metaphor for Fellini’s own fear of creative stagnation. The success of *La Dolce Vita* drove this fear to the forefront of Fellini’s consciousness, and he chose to pursue it as a theme; he himself admits to it - “I would narrate everything that has been happening to me. I would make a

film telling the story of a director who no longer knows what film he wanted to make.” (Bondanella, 2002, p. 98). He uses Guido to work through those feelings, particularly the impotence of process via Guido’s ineffectual and fraught relationships with women; the anima and animus are represented very clearly in Guido’s stunted masculinity (evident in his “creative impotence” and immature sexual / romantic relationships) and the overabundance of feminine energy in the “harem” of women in his personal and professional life. Even the women within the harem - Luisa, Carla, Gloria, the many actresses cast in his film - represent particular dimensions of the animus in their mothering, sexuality, actress fantasies and ego, or philosophizing, and all hold up a mirror to the struggling anima of Guido / Fellini.

Additionally, Jungian psychodrama typically involves imaginative and spontaneous staged performances that not only serve to work through a personal crisis or gain perspective but also apply memory as another tool of self-examination (Scategni, 2014); an interest in subjective memory appears throughout many of Fellini’s films, but in *8 ½* we see Guido having dreams that both reflect some aspect of his objective reality (childhood, his father’s death) but also the accompanying psychological artifacts that those potentially “objective” experiences generated (complex feelings, mental blockages). In psychodrama, dreams and memory are often source material; memory is imbued with the emotion triggered by reminiscence, and dreams are mostly irrational, with no cause and effect (Bondanella, 2002) - using them as a storytelling device inevitably generates a loose sequence of actions that represent a stream of consciousness far more than traditional linear narrative. Fellini’s fascination with the irrationality of dreams is most apparent at this time, unsurprisingly as his meetings with Bernhard encouraged him to keep a dream journal, in which he sketched his dreams (Ariano, 2020; Bondanella, 2002). Strange dreams are woven throughout Guido’s present filmmaking “journey”, contributing to the nonlinear mosaic of Guido’s experience, and give Fellini a container in which to relive and parse the imagery or associated feelings of Guido’s stagnation; he dreams of being trapped in traffic, he dreams of his dead father but can never quite “reach” him, he dreams of his childhood and Saraghina (very much an animus archetype in her sexuality). The compositions (cars crammed together, a strange cemetery, watching Saraghina), lighting (contrast of light and dark), and rhythm of the dream sequences have an expressionist-like quality that underscores Guido’s stress. Ultimately Guido’s (and Fellini’s) psychodrama exercise attempts to reconcile previous lived experience (i.e. subjective memory) with the present crisis of psyche. Whether Fellini achieves this reconciliation, however, is irrelevant to him; he is merely staging the process and emphasizing its creative spontaneity via Guido’s chaotic and unfinished filmmaking efforts. It even seems quite intentional that a film set built upon a film set to replicate a real location would be used to reinforce the “staged” aspect of this psychoanalytical process.

Mirroring and doubling are also apparent in Guido's characterization; in Jungian terms, Fellini is both director and protagonist of this staging, and Guido is Fellini's double, standing in for the frustrated director. Fellini externalizes Guido's inner process considerably in the process of mirroring - using Guido to reflect back to him some perspective that may solve his authorial block or assuage his fear of a creative slump. This stagnation seems to be most expressed in Guido's immaturity when it comes to his relationships, stringing Luisa along as a mother figure and playing juvenile games with Carla (Ariano, 2020); it is also evident in his disinterested engagement in others' manipulations of his film or process, as well as his dreams of childhood. Another aspect of psychodrama in the film is the presence of an "auxiliary ego", which, in psychodrama therapy, is a role assumed by another participant who is responsible for stimulating, guiding, or mirroring the protagonist through their experience (Hill, 2014; Beach, 2014). Daumier acts as one of Guido's auxiliary egos, trying to anchor him to expectations and offer constructive criticism of Guido's project; where Guido seems flighty and untethered, Daumier is a symbol of conventional, rational thought and ideological frameworks that guide filmmaking and attempts to rein in Guido's subjective creativity (Bondanella, 2002). Guido even says, in spite of Daumier's direct criticisms of his film, that he "will be most helpful", although ultimately his utility lies in indirectly reaffirming to Guido his connection with his emotional state. Mezzabotta is another, by discussing his relationship with a much younger woman; Luisa also engenders some psychic activity in Guido, as her shifting moods force an awareness of their marriage. At the end of the film, Guido and Luisa are encircled by all the players in Guido's film production, representing the actual physicality of a psychodrama performance; the egos and archetypes that represent psychological dimensions sit in a circle while the protagonist is central to the action. Ironically, Fellini's implementation of this process while exploiting his own turmoil became the most effective therapeutic process for Fellini himself, as during his process of actively expressing his sense of insufficiency, he overcame it (Kezich, 2015). It could also be argued that *8 ½* was his first large-scale experiment with psychodrama; given the success of *8 ½* both critically and therapeutically, Fellini undoubtedly wanted to utilize this same process to engage in a more intimate staging of self. John Baxter reaffirms this, noting that from *8 ½*'s success came "the need to examine even more thoroughly the sources of his creativity, which lay in dreams, and in his ambiguous sexuality." (Baxter, 2002).

In *Juliet of the Spirits*, Jungian influence is far more overt in aspects of spirit, anima, animus, and acting out a specific form of psychodrama, the fairy tale drama, and develops Fellini's hybrid creative-therapy process further by incorporating fantasy archetypes and aspects of the unconscious in order to dialogue with his own sexuality (Hill, 2014). Jung wrote extensively on notions of spirit as a projection of the self, suggesting that all external projections of spirit (i.e. God) were merely extensions of the psyche in some way (Jung,

1934²). Fellini incorporates this Jungian understanding of “spirit” quite literally into Juliet’s world, as she opens a door and releases spirits that plague her (a very on the nose “metaphor” for opening one’s mind and having to deal with disgorged, repressed feelings against one’s will). There are identifiable archetypes - in basic Jungian terms, there are shadows (literal shadow consuming her husband, Giorgio, herself, and her friends), wise old person (the guru), anima and animus or masculine and feminine (represented by the unbridled or deviant sexuality of Giorgio and Susy and the spirits), mother, maiden (Juliet’s avoidance of sexuality, perhaps represented by her white housecoat with angelic feathery collar) and child (Juliet’s childhood memories). Also present are the auxiliary egos in Juliet’s mother, her friends, Susy, her housekeepers, potentially even Giorgio; Fellini, never one for subtlety, even inserts a psychodramatist character at the end who has Juliet explore her feelings toward Giorgio’s betrayal.

The spirits also have no inherent goodness (or badness), and Fellini played with this ambiguity previously; Jung believed “It can never be established with one-hundred-per-cent certainty whether the spirit-figures in dreams are morally good. Very often they show all the signs of duplicity, if not of outright malice. I must emphasize, however, that the grand plan on which the unconscious life of the psyche is constructed is so inaccessible to our understanding that we can never know what evil may not be necessary in order to produce good by enantiodromia, and what good may very possibly lead to evil.” (Jung, 1934, p. 215). The seemingly mischievous and invasive spirits also appear when Juliet needs answers regarding her feelings toward her loneliness and philandering husband (and possibly stifling urbane expectations), and they represent archetypes relevant to her ongoing feelings - sexual beings, the extreme anima and animus, reflect a preoccupation with repressed sexuality or desire. Even Juliet’s circle of “real-life” friends, such as her close friend who orchestrates the séance, and Susy embody fantasy characters - Susy represents an intensely sexual dimension of psyche, the most condensed version of the feminine “animus”, and every aspect of her life is absurdly hedonistic. The “exotic” guru is a most important archetype; a common characteristic of acting out an inner drama is having a “guide” archetype, who, like the auxiliary ego, pushes the protagonist along a challenging path. Of course every time the protagonist departs the path and returns to “reality”, a spirit acting as an auxiliary ego is there to reorient her on her dramatic journey through the self. Juliet’s costume colors identify her positioning through this journey of self, such as when she dons the color red (especially after learning about Giorgio and Gabriella’s affair; where previously it was an accent, here she is in full red, including lipstick); when she recoils from her new assertiveness to return to familiarity, she returns to her white

² *Archetypes of the Collective Unconscious* was originally written by Jung in 1934 and republished again in 2014

housecoat or a similar pale-colored garment. When the betrayal reaches a climax, she grieves her relationship, wearing a black dress and watching a distant memory of him meeting her mother.

Jung also believed that “psychic forces” had a power that superseded the conscious mind, endowing it with a sort of “magic” (Jung, 1934) - magic is something we often see in Fellini’s films, but particularly in *Juliet*. The oversaturated colors, exaggerated shapes of headdress and costume, mixture of culture and history, lush botanical settings and details, Susy’s fantasy-inspired treehouse and psychedelic stained-glass mansion, overflowing floral bouquets and garden motifs at Juliet’s and her Susy’s homes, dreamlike processions of unusual characters, and emphasis on heightened sensory experience (notably Juliet rubbing a velvet table early in the film, intensely visible textures in costumes and sets, the guru discussing sensuality and sangria’s “thirst” quenching, the orgy, mentions of Susy’s grandmothers intoxicating wildflower perfume) contribute to the magic and reinforce the personal “fairy tale” element. John Hill notes in a study of Jungian psychodrama technique that the utility of fairy tale drama is that it “provides a framework through which we can weave together strands of our personality that would otherwise go unnoticed or be acted out in an unconscious manner” (Hill, 2014, p. 109) and “attempts to connect the personal with the archetypal in ways that address the plight of contemporary humanity who cannot find home in a purely functional world of artifacts.” (Hill, 2014, p. 113). The timeless, illusory images and archetypes (symbols of her darkest unconscious and of her humanity) frighten Juliet, and when the fright is revealed to be nothing more than just a feeling that can be overcome, they empower Juliet to identify and express the most hidden aspects of self. The mixture of cultures - early Roman, 1960s Italy, and perhaps ancient forest magic - and aesthetics on screen underscores the distraction of a “world of artifacts”; Juliet, while plagued by the spirits, is still being offered a psychic detour to explore her sexuality or accept Giorgio as he is (possibly Fellini’s own “psychic request” to Masini to accept his indiscretions as innate to his sexuality - perhaps there is an argument to be made that he would have embraced polyamory if given the opportunity), but her urbane life and routine habits call her back repeatedly; when the interminable frenzy of disruptive spirits and memories force her to look past the irrelevant artifacts of her life, and reconcile the watchful, judgemental eye of her memories, the sexual frustration of her reality, and her conflicted fantasies with her present feelings.

Prior to this reconciliation, Juliet nearly allows the spirits to consume her, finally acknowledging these hidden representatives of her pained psyche, where previously she ran from them or denied their existence; the psychodramatist, the very unobtrusive symbol of therapy facilitation, is the only tether to the rational, “real” world. She reverts to a child and begs for help from her mother, then suddenly is no longer afraid; she realizes these seemingly external figures will not help her, as the help she needs is within, and that is the moment she

rescues her inner child and frees the spirits from their earthly plane. when the interminable frenzy of disruptive spirits and memories force her to look past the irrelevant artifacts of her life, and reconcile the watchful, judgemental eye of her memories, the sexual frustration of her reality, and her conflicted fantasies with her present feelings. The whole entire psychodrama process is, of course, facilitated by her conversations with her friends, the auxiliary egos, the susurrations of the spirits, the psychodramatist character, who elucidates Juliet's struggle in plain language for her and our benefit, and her "facing her fear" by way of attempting to meet Gabriella; it all leads to her accepting both herself, and by extension, accepting Giorgio.

Fellini also cast his wife for this role; if *8 ½* was a mirror to the audience, then here Juliet is perhaps the same, in addition to being a mirror for both Masini and Fellini (who, like his characters, is rumored to have philandering tendencies despite loving his wife) - it is the ultimate couple's therapy, involving role-playing a mix of memory and fantasy in order to achieve some wholeness or understanding of each other (and although they nearly divorced, circumstance kept them together and, in hindsight, that acceptance and understanding came over time). But again, Fellini was undoubtedly most concerned with holding the mirror up to the audience as well, sometimes even literally; Susy at one point holds up a mirror while talking to Juliet, giving us a view of her face (although Juliet cannot see her). Her friends and the private investigator offer their opinions on the matter of Giorgio, again holding up a kind of mirror to the possibilities of how we would respond in the same situation.

It is undeniable that Fellini's preoccupations with memory, dream, fantasy, psychology, and individual psyche are explored in every one of his films (to varying degrees); *8 ½* and *Juliet of the Spirits* are notable especially for the intimacy between art, artist, and viewer - there is a heightened exchange of vulnerability between Fellini himself and his audience that is not present in his other films (not even in *Intervista*). The films prior to his meetings with his psychoanalyst Bernhard, and those after *Juliet of the Spirits* (perhaps really after *Fellini Satyricon*, although it is not based on his own source material) hold a mirror up to the audience, using a variety of archetypes and film styles, to encourage us to reflect on where and how we relate to the characters - this is evidence of our relationship to humanity at large. *8 ½* and *Juliet* go further, and instead of a mirror, Fellini is holding himself up in front of us, engaging in Jungian psychodrama as our mirror, and asks us to reflect on where and how his own personal drama and psyche connect to ours. Given his revulsion toward television and his concerns that it lacked intimacy, it stands to reason that these are his most intimate films, and his greatest experimentation in connecting with an audience. The degree of truth is also irrelevant; we are not comparing ourselves to his life as much as his innate humanness. Hill succinctly sums up the utility of Jungian psychodrama and ultimately captures the essence of Fellini's intent: "Through internalizing the symbolic intentions of these archetypal figures and amplifying them through mind, memory, emotion, and body,

we become aware of the deepest levels of the personal psyche that are embedded in an impersonal, universal landscape essential for survival, health, and fulfillment. Within this matrix, the human becomes truly human.” (Hill, 2014, p. 113). Within Fellini’s films, especially when we actively participate in the audience as practitioners of Jungian group drama therapy, we are ultimately participating in our own humanity, becoming in essence “truly human”.

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